STEP 1: CAREER & INCOME

Choose a career and calculate your monthly take-home pay.

MISSION #1

My name _____ **Date** _____

1 Pick a real career

2025 U.S. median hourly pay, rounded down—not starting or apprentice pay. Work 40 paid hours each week.



Graphic designer
Create visual designs
$30 / hour
Typical qualification Bachelor's degree



Veterinary technician
Help care for animals
$22 / hour
Typical qualification Associate degree + state credential



Software developer
Build apps and programs
$65 / hour
Typical qualification Bachelor's degree



Electrician
Install and repair electrical systems
$30 / hour
Typical qualification High school + apprenticeship



Plumber
Install and repair water pipes
$30 / hour
Typical qualification High school + apprenticeship



HVAC technician
Service heating and cooling systems
$29 / hour
Typical qualification Trade training; EPA certification for refrigerant work

2 Find your monthly income

Gross pay is money earned before taxes. Take-home pay is what you can budget.

Work rule: 40 hours/week × 52 weeks/year ÷ 12 months. Round down to whole dollars at each step.

1. Weekly gross pay	_____	× 40 =	_____
2. Average monthly gross	_____	× 52 ÷ 12 =	_____
3. Estimated monthly taxes Federal + NC + Social Security/Medicare			_____

Monthly take-home pay

Monthly gross – estimated taxes. Use this for your budget. _____

Our example household

One adult renting in Raleigh, North Carolina. Pay uses 2025 national medians; tax rules and local cost references are from 2026. Expenses are realistic planning estimates, not exact bills. A month is not always four weeks.

★ OPTIONAL · TRY A CHALLENGE

What is your gross pay for a whole year?

_____

STEP 2: HOUSING & TRANSPORTATION

Compare homes, utility bills, and monthly transportation costs.

MISSION #2

A **need** helps you live and stay well, like food and a safe home. Choose a home and travel for one adult. All costs below are monthly.

1 Choose your home

Raleigh rental scenarios—not mortgages or measured averages by home type.



Cozy apartment
1 bedroom · 750 sq ft



Townhouse
2 bedrooms · 1,200 sq ft



House
3 bedrooms · 1,800 sq ft

Estimated rent and utility bills · per month

Monthly bill	Apartment	Townhouse	House
Rent only	**$1,300**	**$1,900**	**$2,300**
Electricity Includes heating & cooling	$105	$150	$210
Water & sewer	$60	$75	$80
Trash	$20	$25	$30
Utilities only Rent is NOT included	**$185**	**$250**	**$320**

Estimates for all-electric homes. Bigger spaces, weather, water use, and the lease change bills. Internet is budgeted separately. How we estimated these bills.

2 Choose how to travel

Choose one transportation plan for your monthly budget.



Walk or bike
$20 / month
Already-owned bicycle. $20 per month set aside for upkeep.



Public Transit
$80 / month
GoTriangle adult fare cap: up to $80 per month.



Car
$780 / month
Financed car; about 1,000 miles per month. Includes payment, fuel, insurance, upkeep and registration.

Transport bills · per month

N/A = no bill for this option. Costs & assumptions

Monthly bill	Walk / bike	Public Transit	Car
Car payment	N/A	N/A	$350
Gas / fuel	N/A	N/A	$150
Vehicle insurance	N/A	N/A	$160
Public Transit pass	N/A	$80	N/A
Maintenance & repairs Monthly upkeep set-aside	$20	N/A	$100
Registration & vehicle taxes Annual costs set aside monthly	N/A	N/A	$20
Total monthly transport	**$20**	**$80**	**$780**

Name: _____ Raleigh estimates: Numbeo, EnergySage, MIT & GoTriangle. See research notes for assumptions.

STEP 2: HOUSING & TRAVEL TOTALS

Record your selected home and transportation costs.

MISSION #2

Use your selected home and travel plan from the previous page. Add rent, utilities, transportation, and renters insurance. Daily living bills are on Step 3.

Rent only	_____
Utilities only	_____
Renters insurance	$20
Housing Subtotal	_____
Transportation Subtotal	_____

Why did you choose this home or way to travel?

STEP 3: LIFESTYLE & SAVINGS

Plan daily living expenses, lifestyle bills, and monthly savings.

MISSION #3

Budget for one adult in Raleigh, NC. All amounts are monthly estimates. These living bills are separate from the housing and transportation costs in Step 2.

Daily Living & Lifestyle Bills

Groceries & food	$400
Home internet / Wi-Fi	$70
Mobile phone plan	$55
Health insurance & medical care	$280
Clothing, toiletries & household supplies	$150
Streaming services & gaming	$30
Monthly living-bills subtotal	**$985**

Pay Yourself First: Savings

Savings goal _____

Monthly savings amount $ _____

Choose Your Fun-Money Budget

Free outings	Dining out & treats	Movies & hobbies
$0 / month	$50 / month	$100 / month

Selected fun-money allowance	_____
Monthly savings	_____
Total lifestyle & savings	_____

★ OPTIONAL · TRY A CHALLENGE

If you save the same amount for 3 months, how much will you have?

_____

Name: _____ Food and medical benchmarks: MIT. Internet/phone: Numbeo. Other amounts are monthly planning allowances.

STEP 4: BUDGET CHECK & REFLECTION

Compare your monthly income with expenses and savings.

FINAL STEP

Review your monthly cash flow. Transfer the subtotals from Steps 2 and 3, then compare total expenses and savings with your monthly take-home income.

Budget Summary Table

Category Description	Monthly Total ($)
TOTAL MONTHLY INCOME (A) Take-home pay after estimated taxes	_____
Housing Subtotal Rent + utilities + renters insurance	_____
Transportation Subtotal Selected travel plan, including all applicable costs	_____
Lifestyle & Savings Subtotal Daily living bills + fun money + monthly savings	_____
TOTAL MONTHLY EXPENSES (B) Housing + transportation + lifestyle & savings	_____

This cash-flow budget includes savings in (B) because that money is set aside. Savings remains your money—it is not a purchase. Taxes have already been deducted from (A); do not count them again.

Monthly income (A) – monthly expenses (B)

Net Remaining Cash _____

A negative balance is a deficit; zero is balanced; a positive balance is a surplus.

1. **Is your monthly budget balanced, in surplus, or in deficit? What adjustment would you make?**

2. **Which category—housing, transportation, or lifestyle and savings—has the largest subtotal?**

3. **An unexpected repair costs $150. Can your net remaining cash cover it? If not, how would you fund the repair?**

SAVINGS RATE

Calculate the percentage of monthly income allocated to savings.

(Monthly savings ÷ monthly income A) × 100. Use a calculator if needed.

_____